

Chapter 121_2 - Old Friend

The wind and sand were shut out beyond the earth's surface. Before them burned a roaring campfire, illuminating the large space under the rocks brightly. Ning Fuyi stood surveying their surroundings.

Most of the people present looked familiar. Sitting by the campfire was Tang Wenshu¹, the sect leader of Heaven Profound Sword Sect. When he saw Ning Fuyi, he was first stunned for a moment, then smiled and stood up: "It's been many years. Now I should address you as the Hall Master of Cowering Hall."

"Sect Leader Tang needn't be particular about titles - just call me by name," Ning Fuyi nodded at him.

Tang Wenshu had bloodstains on his robes, presumably having been injured in the fierce wind earlier. Around him were two disciples from Heaven Profound Sword Sect who stood up following Tang Wenshu, but kept their heads lowered, not daring to look at Ning Fuyi.

Ning Fuyi didn't take offense. In the eyes of the immortal sects, she wasn't a good person, and with her unclear connections to demons, it was natural for immortal sect members to fear her.

There weren't many people remaining here - presumably some had already died or been injured. Besides Liu Wenzhu and Baili Shiqi, there were only two men sitting in the corner. One was dressed like a wealthy young master, holding his sword and staring at the two women. The other was simply dressed with a thin build.

"Uncle Tang, since this person is connected to the demon clan, why let her stay with us?" The young man who looked like a wealthy master stood up, staring at Ning Fuyi as he spoke.

"Hua Feiwu², you've done nothing but hold us back this entire journey. What right do you have to speak up now! If it weren't for Sect Leader Hua Hong³ entrusting Uncle Tang to train you, I would have thrown you into that wind and sand long ago!"

Liu Wenzhu spoke coldly from behind, dropping her thousand-pound hammer⁴ on the ground with a thud, the wind making the firelight dance wildly.

Though Hua Feiwu was in the wrong, his arrogant nature, fostered by his status, made him completely unrepentant: "So what? My father entrusted me to Uncle Tang, not to you. If you don't want to travel with me, then leave by yourself - who wants you around!"

Liu Wenzhu was about to argue further when Tang Wenshu quickly mediated: "Wenzhu, Hua Feiwu, Divine Physician Jiang's life and death are uncertain, and this place is full of dangers. How can we have internal conflicts?"

"My apologies, Sect Leader Tang," Liu Wenzhu restrained her temper and bowed to Tang Wenshu, then walked past Ning Fuyi. "Come on, let's go to the side."

Ning Fuyi calmly listened to all their words without saying much.

"By the way, we found a young lady at the edge of the boulder formation earlier. Wenzhu said she's a disciple of Divine Venerable Chu Ling - she must have gotten separated from your group!" Baili Shiqi suddenly remembered this matter, also breaking the silence.

The three women's hearts dropped and then rose again with anxiety. Jiuying stepped forward: "Where is she?"

"There," Baili Shiqi led them to a corner shrouded in darkness. On the ground was someone's cloak, and Qiu Yi was curled up in it, sleeping with her eyes closed.

Chu Qingqiu quickly walked to her, crouched down to check her pulse, her fingertips relaxing slightly as she looked up: "She's fine, just sleeping."

Only then did Jiuying pat her chest and laugh: "This little bird really has nine lives⁵ - she managed to walk out of those boulders in such a state."

Chu Qingqiu lowered her gaze again, her eyes lingering on Qiu Yi's furrowed brow for a while before reaching out to smooth it: "Let her sleep for a while."

Liu Wenzhu found a corner of the cave to start another fire, then took tea utensils from her storage pouch and began brewing tea. Ning Fuyi and the others all sat around the campfire, falling into silence for a moment.

Ning Fuyi naturally missed Liu Wenzhu greatly, but after thirty years had passed - though thirty years was but a blink of an eye for immortals, for mortals it was like watching seas turn to mulberry fields⁶. Combined with Liu Wenhai's death, things had inevitably grown distant.

Those youthful days of daily companionship would also develop barriers due to time.

Chu Qingqiu was never one for many words, and Jiuying was happy to watch the excitement without speaking. Fortunately, among them was the carefree Baili Shiqi, who was chattering and laughing cheerfully, pulling out various foods and snacks from her pouch to distribute to everyone.

"Sister Jiuying, here's your roasted chicken," she smiled sweetly as she stuffed a paper package into Jiuying's hands. "I originally came to Xuanyuan Kingdom alone, but without realizing it, I flew into that miasma and was nearly devoured by it. Fortunately, Sister Wenzhu noticed something was wrong and saved my life with her sword."

"While talking with her, I learned that she and Sister Ning are close friends. Sister Ning is a good person, so Sister Ning's friend is naturally also a good person. Sister Ning and I truly have a rare connection!"

She tilted her head with a bright smile as she looked at Ning Fuyi. Across from them, Chu Qingqiu suddenly crushed the teacup in her hand without changing expression, paused for a moment, then used immortal power to restore it.

Jiuying was sitting close enough to see her action completely, so she secretly leaned over and said: "Divine Venerable, don't mind it. Shiqi just has that kind of welcoming personality. When you died and Ning Fuyi was imprisoned by Penglai and nearly turned to madness, it was this girl who saved her from fire and water."

After speaking, she smiled as she unwrapped the paper package to eat the roasted chicken, but her own teacup somehow shattered into pieces.

Then her hand trembled, and the roasted chicken accidentally fell at her feet.

"Hiss..." Jiuying said.

Author's Note:

Jiuying: If I had known sister was so petty, little sister wouldn't have said that extra word.

Footnotes:

1. **Tang Wenshu (唐温书)** - Sect Leader of Heaven Profound Sword Sect, a major character who has appeared throughout the story
2. **Hua Feiwu (花非雾)** - A spoiled young master from Flying Flower Sect, known for his arrogant behavior
3. **Sect Leader Hua Hong (花鸿教主)** - The leader of Flying Flower Sect and Hua Feiwu's father
4. **Thousand-pound hammer (千斤锤)** - Liu Wenzhu's signature weapon, indicating her immense physical strength
5. **Nine lives** - A reference to the saying about cats having nine lives, used here to describe someone's remarkable survival ability
6. **Seas turn to mulberry fields (沧海桑田)** - A Chinese idiom meaning great changes over time, referring to how dramatically things can change